

100 Days of Azure DevOps

Day 74 Handout — The rule is the condition; the action group is the destination — a rule with nobody to email is performance art

8 - Monitoring & Observability · Personal lab only · Educational content · Not a sales pitch

Architecture A — rule, condition, action group, severity

Piece	What it is	Lab choice
Action group	Destination list: email, SMS, webhook, ITSM, ARM	Email yourself (personal). Proof of delivery today
Metric alert	Platform metric threshold (CPU, availability)	Something you can provoke on a tiny SKU or availability test
Log alert	KQL that returns rows → fire	AzureActivity or App Insights requests failed > N
Severity	Sev 0–4 language	Sev 3 for lab. If everything is Sev 0, nothing is
Fired vs resolved	State. Noise trains mute	One clean fire beats ten flaps. Delete with the resource

Architecture B — action group first, then a condition you can force

Constraint	Default	Avoid
Destination	Action group ag-lab-email → personal inbox	Disabled mailbox / team DL you do not own
Condition	Availability ping on a URL you control, or a metric you can lift	5xx on an app with zero traffic — never graduates from theory
Window	1–5 min evaluation for a lab	24h window so you never see it fire today
Smart detection only	Fine as a bonus, not the only pager	Assuming App Insights emails you without an action group
After the lab	Delete the alert with the resource	Orphan rules firing for a year

Architecture C — pitfalls that scream into the void

Pitfall	What you see	Fix
Rule, no action group	Monitor shows Fired; inbox silent	Attach ag-lab-email. Then check spam
Action group, no rule	Theatre	Create one alert that uses it
Cannot provoke	You never received the email; assumed it works	Force CPU / stop the app / fail a test. Receipt required
Sev 0 for disk 70%	Mute culture	Sev 3 lab; reserve 0 for wake-me
Work SMS / PagerDuty	Employer on-call in a personal series	Personal email only

One-liner to remember

Alerts without action groups are screams into the void — polite, useless. Scream at an inbox that exists. An alert you have never received is a rumor about the future.

Step-by-step lab (personal Azure / Azure DevOps only)

Personal subscription. Action group emails your personal address. One alert you can fire. Delete it when you delete the resource.

- 1 Monitor → Alerts → Action groups → Create ag-lab-email, short name labag, email receiver = your personal address.

- 2 Create one alert rule: either a metric you can provoke, a standard availability test on a URL you control, or a log alert on a KQL you can satisfy. Severity 3. Attach ag-lab-email.
- 3 Fire it (stop the app, exceed CPU on a tiny VM, or generate the log rows). Wait the evaluation window.
- 4 Confirm the email arrived. If not: spam, action group receiver confirmed, alert Fired state in Portal. The lab is not done until delivery or a written blocker.
- 5 Note the difference between Fired and a dashboard glance. Live metrics (Day 73) are not this.
- 6 Write docs/alerts-day74.md: rule name, condition, action group, whether mail arrived. Plan to delete the rule with the resource so it does not flap for a year.

Starter CLI — action group, then a metric alert

```
az monitor action-group create -g rg-day74 -n ag-lab-email --short-name labag \
  --email-receiver name=me email=<personal@email>
# Example metric alert (swap --scopes for a VM or App Service you can provoke):
az monitor metrics alert create -g rg-day74 -n lab-cpu-or-availability \
  --scopes <resource-id> \
  --condition "avg Percentage CPU > 80" \
  --window-size 5m --evaluation-frequency 1m \
  --action ag-lab-email --severity 3
# Availability tests: Portal → App Insights → Availability → add test → that action group.
```

Done checklist

- Action group emails the personal inbox
- One alert rule attached to that group
- Tried to receive the email (or documented the blocker)
- Severity chosen on purpose; delete plan written

Tomorrow — Day 75

Dashboards and workbooks — three tiles, not a 30-minute novel